



Issue #5: The Next Smash Bros.

Before the most recent Nintendo Direct, about 90 percent of all gamers were convinced they were going to get some news on new content for Super Smash Bros., whether it was DLC or enhancements for Ultimate or a new installment entirely. Instead, everyone was severely misdirected with the reveal of a new Kirby game.

Personally, I do not have any problems with there not being a new Smash game. After all, nothing is going to top Ultimate. However, I admit that because iconic fighting games are eternal, that Super Smash Bros. should be no exception.

In this issue of the Icebox, I will discuss two things: 1) what I realistically expect for a new Smash game and 2) how I would design a new installment after Ultimate.

The expectations for a new Smash game are quite high, but first let's go over the possibility of new content for Ultimate. If the current directors for Nintendo were smart, they would egg Sakurai and his team to fix the online-gameplay in Ultimate. That is easily the worst part of the game and has been a continuous issue since release.

Let's suppose a new update to Ultimate targeted the main problems in the game. The online mode, some rendering issues, and a balance patch that nerfs Steve would easily revive the game, despite such a move not even introducing new content. Another way to expand the playerbase would be to bring back every single music track used in the game, especially the collection from Brawl that was left out. Of course, this is a solution that involves licensing and asking permission from the original composers. However, I doubt at this point in time that it would be difficult to accomplish.

Beyond these changes are, of course, adding new content to the game. I think the best thing to do is add at least three more DLC characters and stages. This would get people to play the game and build up hype for Nintendo projects in general.

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Written by Master Freeze

The question is, what characters could possibly be added at this time? The addition of Sora was portrayed as a grand finale to the Smash franchise, though most people know it's never truly over. A game like Super Smash Bros. should not see a realistic end due to the amount of money it brings to Nintendo and the massive community that is centered around it. The realistic option for new characters would be from the latest Nintendo games, which would probably include at least one Fire Emblem character. I think another approach would be that a new rendition of Mario, Link, or Donkey Kong might be included as separate characters.

However, my personal choice would be to add only one more character to the roster. This would be none other than Tabuu, the master of the subspace. He was not only the final boss in Super Smash Bros. Brawl's Subspace Emissary, but his design would work very well as a playable fighter. He is also canonically superior to Master Hand and presumably Crazy Hand. It just makes sense that there should be at least one proprietary character within the Smash franchise. I also support that Tabuu would be the most top-tier character in the game, even above Steve (who should be nerfed).

Along with Tabuu, I would add options to change Final Destination and Battlefield to any of the versions from the previous Smash games. I would also make The Final Battle from World of Light a stage, where the hazards include Galeem and Dharkon. Finally, I would add the Subspace stage that appears when you fight Tabuu.

Ultimate is already a complete game for the most part. It is lacking proper online support and could use a few features here and there for improvement. However, should there be a new update for any reason, I believe in what I have said.

With all of that being said, I think a new Smash game with a completely new direction is more likely. We live in a newly evolved era of video games, and while Nintendo is usually indifferent to such progress, I think the influence will be apparent considering Nintendo has changed a lot in the last seven years.

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A new Smash game, as Nintendo would pursue, would be a soft reboot of the game. It would probably include the original twelve characters and most of the characters in Brawl. I think the third-party characters would be mostly scrapped, with the exception of some like Sonic, Pac-Man, possibly Ryu, and maybe Joker. In any case, I think the base roster will be entirely Nintendo characters.

Suppose this was true. Each character has evolved a lot over the years. All of them would receive a complete redesign. Appearances would match more recent games. Movesets would be more diversified and equal among characters.

Another thing that is very likely is that the next Smash game is more story-based or cinematic, just like Super Smash Bros. Brawl. I actually think a sequel to Subspace Emissary is long overdue. With the chance at new game direction in a new Smash game, I think we may see a smaller roster that focuses more on the characters' interactions like in Brawl. The base roster will be primarily Nintendo characters with a sprinkle of third parties. The DLC will probably be only third-parties. I expect the roster would not be any bigger than maybe 40 characters in total.

The way that I would design a new Smash game would be vastly different and perhaps controversial. Personally, I am curious to see how a 2D classic-format Smash game would look like. If you didn't know, Super Smash Bros. is a platform fighter that has percent-based damage and knockback. Masahiro Sakurai, the creator of Smash, Kirby, and Kid Icarus, designed Smash after getting frustrated with standard fighting games. In a regular fighting game, you have a health bar and limited space to control your character. If your health bar is depleted, you lose. Sakurai wanted to design a game where a person's fate was not determined by a health bar and the character had more freedom to move around. His solution was a platformer game with fighting mechanics, where higher percent means higher launchability. This ensured that even a newbie would have a fighting chance against a polished veteran due to the unpredictability and diverse patterns of gameplay. Of course, most of this has been boiled down after twenty years of the franchise and genre existing.

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This is another reason why I think Nintendo should attempt a 2D version of Smash. Imagine if the roster was only twenty of Nintendo's most popular characters. Each of them is given a new moveset to better fit the 2D style. It's true their movesets are already pretty adaptable, but for the sake of gameplay it is probably better to bring something fresh and new. The stages in the game can represent different games or even locations related to Nintendo such as Nintendo HQ, Nintendo Universal, or some proprietary locations that tie-in all of the aspects of Nintendo together.

The game would work just like other fighting games, using health bars and supers instead of stocks and Smash balls. As you may know, Super Smash Bros. games have customizable rulesets to almost replicate these dynamics already. This new type of Smash would be no exception. Perhaps there could still be a way to use stocks, Smash balls, and items in a 2D format.

I think it's worth pursuing this type of game. It does not have to be a huge title either. It is simply worth trying for those that enjoy fighting games as a whole. Who is to say there can't be two different kinds of Smash in the future? Or perhaps it can be implemented within the next Smash game as a separate mode entirely. With better technology and safe processing, it is not a far reach.

In any case, a completely new Smash game has only two possible routes. Either find a way to somehow blow Ultimate out of the water, or take on a new direction entirely to represent a new era of the iconic franchise. The latter seems to be a trend with Nintendo, considering Super Mario Bros. Wonder, Donkey Kong Bananza, the new Metroid games, Splatoon Raiders, Pokemon, Pikmin, WarioWare, and more.

Unlike the case with Ultimate, I am no longer hungry to the brink of severe impatience for new Smash content. I believe I have closed my chapter on the franchise until I am truly impressed with something new. Smash is still one of my favorite games of all time, but I no longer get itchy to play it.

That's it for this issue of the Icebox. Chill out!